maybe five came in, but these five became the starting point for reaching out to others.'[40]

The new quotas were a means of breaking into new communities. A Brahmin district general secretary spoke to me about the initial internal reluctance to the party's new organisational quotas and the impact of the change. He recalled that he went to have tea for the first time in a Valmiki basti. 'I am a Brahmin,' he said. 'I have a mandir in my house. If anyone comes, they cannot enter my house without having a bath. But this was sangathan work and we were told to enrol Dalits. I myself went to a Valmiki basti and had tea. Many people next to me said, how can we do this? They said no. The day I had tea in one Valmiki's house, one thing changed. After that, if I had to organise a crowd for a rally, through that one person's medium, in whose house I had tea, I could fill one bus of people for the rally from his Valmiki basti. This experience taught me that if just one cup of tea can bring you fifty people for a bus for Delhi–Lucknow, then imagine the possibility if you work with them more. I found it was more uneasy to work with Brahmins and Baniyas. With Dalits, it is easier if you work with them, because you get respect faster if you honour them.'[41]

These quotas were politically instrumental, for sure. But they also brought in a new base of voters to the party. The BJP believes that many voters in that Valmiki basti gravitated to the party for the first time in the assembly elections that followed. In Mathura city, for example, the upper-caste population is about 65 per cent. But in July 2020, the BJP's elected mayor in the city was a Dalit in a non-reserved post.[42] 'If in such a seat, our mahapaur [mayor] is SC, then you can imagine yourself,' summed up another local party official.[43]

A Digital Party: Lists, Zoom Calls and Targeted Politics during the National Lockdown

This restructuring and expansion of the BJP was accompanied by the creation of an effective oversight mechanism. When I met a group of district-level BJP workers in UP in July 2020, in the middle of the COVID-19 lockdown, they explained how their work was